



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with PW

Anonymous (PW)

26th July 2018

Location: Queen's University Belfast

Interviewed by Ida Milne

Transcribed by Olivia Dee

PW's explained that she became pregnant at fifteen (at a date during the 1970s) and was sent to a Good Shepherd mother and baby home by her parents. PW explained that she came forward to offer an interview because she had a good experience with the Good Shepherd Sisters and wanted to contribute her account to the research. She described the mother and baby institution as a 'safe' place for her. PW explained that her father reacted with a great deal of anger to the news that she was pregnant and her mother feared he could become violent. PW revealed that her time spent with the Good Shepherd Sisters was different from other women whose accounts she had read in media reports about the history of mother and baby homes. PW was not required to carry out heavy chores, such as scrubbing floors on her knees. She recalled only the type of housework that was performed in her own family home. Moreover, some of her time was taken up studying for CSE exams that she sat in the convent. During her time with the Good Shepherd Sisters, PW had a miscarriage scare and was hospitalised briefly. PW was the youngest mother-to-be in the home at that point, the oldest being around 30. The girls and women came from a variety of occupational backgrounds and there was one young woman from a Protestant family in the Republic of Ireland. PW took her baby home with her and explained that no one pressurised her to think about an adoption. Her mother was a strong factor in this outcome, as she insisted that PW bring her baby home and made no secret of the pregnancy. However, PW does recall some of the negative reaction from former school friends when she wheeled her baby through the local streets.

Names, dates and locations have been anonymised to protect the identity of PW, her family and other individuals featured in the testimony. Redactions are indicated by **.

IM: So, I'm just started this recording now and it is ... the date is the 26th of July 2018 and we are in the office of the Northern Ireland Mother and Baby Homes and Magdalene Laundries investigations in Queen's. I am the oral history researcher, Ida Milne, and I'm here with an interviewee who is going to talk about her time in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*.

PW: I ... approximately the middle of *date in 1970s*, I found out I was pregnant. I was about five months pregnant. I was fifteen. And there was a social worker got and all that and I was [coughing] ... Because I come from a very devout Catholic family, my mother and father, and a big family, there was nine of us, I was put into the Good Shepherd Convent *location*. Within a few days ... there was no messing about ... I was there and I stayed there until towards the end of *month*. My baby was born on the *date* and approximately a week later I was home with baby, with my mother and dad. I ... I have read in the papers and that about the bad negative experiences that people have had and I felt that I have to come forward almost as a debt of honour. It is a debt of honour actually, because it was a safe place for me to be in. I was away from my father. My mother was very, very good. My father ... no, it would have been ... even when he died *date*, it still ... he never forgive me for having a child before I was married. But, I found the home ... yes ... it ... it ... it was lonely, there's no two ways about that, it was lonely. But it was a safe place. Nobody used surnames, it was all Christian names, just ... There

was two nuns, trained child ... a trained children's nurse, Sister W and another nun who was a trained midwife, Sister G. And they ran *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. And the battered wives hostel, that was right beside it.

IM: And that had a separate entrance I think? You told me?

PW: Yeh ... there's two entrances to the Good Shephard Convent on the *location*

IM: OK.

PW: And you went in that way. In and out that way. The top end was into the main convent and that. When you were there a few days or that, Sister D, who was the Reverend Mother, Mother D, you went up and she spoke to you, up in her ... must have been the nun's parlour or whatever. And she was very nice as well. It was ... she talked about: "What were you gonna do with your baby?" And she said her ... she didn't worry about the girls who came to the convent and had their children, she worried about girls who went to England. And at the time I didn't realise, being only sixteen, that she meant abortions. I ... I just didn't twig at that time that's what she meant. So, that was all very well. You had a structured regime in it, but everybody has a structured regime, you have to. A time for getting up, a time for eating, a time for chores, going to bed, rest, whatever. I ... there was no ... none of this down on your hands and knees scrubbing floors or anything like that. It was housework duties that you would do every day at home anyway. I hadn't been well and had been in *hospital* and had to rest, so they ... this ... I'm sort of jumping forward a bit here. A couple of weeks after I went in I had a threatened miscarriage, so the nuns got an ambulance straight away and I was sent to ... hospital. All the babies were

born in *name of hospital*, none in my experience, were ever born in the convent. In the *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, they were all born in *name of hospital*. And you'd come back then to the ... to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* with your baby and whether your baby was going for adoption after a few weeks or whatever, or six weeks, then the social workers intervened and it was them that took the babies away. I, at that time ... there was approximately fourteen to fifteen girls between ... I was the youngest and then there was girls in, I would say, maybe their early thirties, up to that age? There was qualified nurses, there was professional girls, women and non-professional people, but you know, there was a variety across the board of girls, women who were in it. And you had an individual dormitory. There was ... it was partitioned up about six, seven feet ... eight feet into the air but you had your bed, like a wee dressing table, wardrobe and sink. There was bathroom facilities, and all that just outside.

IM: That's better than many of us would have had at home.

PW: Yeah. We had an outside toilet until I was ten years old. You know, it ... you ... you were expected just to do some of the chores. I done the dusting because I was supposed to be resting. Then after lunch you would have been encouraged to go back to bed for a while, to lie down. Any of the pregnant mothers could've, or any of the women who already had their babies could have rested in the afternoon. And then, I suppose about three, half-three you woulda had like, tea or whatever and you knitted or crocheted, painted ... whatever was your point, whatever you want ... there was one girl who painted, she was into painting and then ... well I was in to knitting and crocheting. So, that's what I done. You done baby clothes, like matinee jackets, wee crocheted dresses, you know? All of those things that were, at the time, in fashion, shall we say? Where for boys [it] was just baby grows. White, blue or ye ... lemon, that was it. So, I

found it not negative. I found it a safe place to be. It also ... the nuns in ... where I went to school and the nuns in the Good Shephard Convent ... arranged between them for me to do my school exams in *name of mother and baby home*. And that was GCSEs in 197*. At that stage I wasn't deemed to be able to cope with the GCSEs. If they were just ... I think they were just coming in then. But I done my CSEs and the nuns between them arranged this. And they also arranged for a lady to sit with me from the school I attended before I went to *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. So my CSEs were done there and there was no problem. I was given ... it was actually ... I done them up in the Battered Wives hostel because there was nobody in it at that stage.¹ Now I'm not being derogatory when I say battered wives, but that's what it was called then.

IM: That's the term we used here.

PW: Yeah.

IM: Yeah.

PW: And there was women coming and going from it, a lot of the time. But that's ... it was a safe haven for them. The nuns ... Sister G would have interviewed you and you know, asked who was the name ... the father of the child. I didn't say who the father was and she asked me: "Was he a married man?" She was a bit horrified. And I said: "No, he wasn't" and he wasn't. He was just a lad a couple of years older than me and we'd been going together for ... I was young. Anyway, there was no pressure ever put on me at any time to give my baby up for adoption or fostering or anything, thank God. A few of the

¹ A separate part of the convent that housed victims of domestic violence.

girls, it was no other option, they felt, but adoption. Some talked about fostering, putting their child in for long-term fostering. There was actually a lady who lived in *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home* who had a baby, was I would say, approximately, maybe eight and she worked in *location outside the mother and baby home* and her child was long-term fostered and she seen her child every weekend. So, and then the nuns accommodated that. So lived there and she worked in *location outside the mother and baby home* and ...

IM: So, she actually lived in *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home* still?

PW: Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. And had been there for a good number of years I would say. Reading between the lines, I got the impression that she was living there since she had her child. And the ... the nuns were very good, they were always on hand. Sister G slept just across the corridor from the dormitories where she could've ... she was on hand is she was needed. I ... I couldn't say anything bad about it. You were free to go in and out of [the home] as you wanted ... and you ... you were ... there was a ... a wee shop ... So you were able to walk down to it, buy whatever you wanted and back up again. You could walk *name of hospital* for your antenatal appointments, or if the weather was bad or you weren't up for walking Sister W would've drove you in and dropped you off. And would've come back and picked you up. They did encourage the mothers ... once you had your baby you were moved from the dormitories up into another ... bay shall we say? Where you were nearer the nursery for your child, to be able to get up in the middle of the night and feed, or whatever. The ambulance took you back from *name of hospital* after you were deemed fit to be discharged from the maternity ward.

IM: So you would've been quite a long time in *name of hospital* do you think?

PW: No, well then you were talking about a week.

IM: OK.

PW: In them days it was a week, [now] six hours you're lucky if you get in, six hours and you're tidied up and threw out again.

IM: [speaks at the same time, inaudible]

PW: Again, *name of hospital* was very good.

IM: Yeah.

PW: I had a ... there was two consultant gynaecologists. A Mr B and a Mr C. Mr C then moved on to *name of another hospital* but I do remember when I was in with a threatened miscarriage, him asking me why I was ... what ... what ... what was I going to do with my baby? And I said: "My baby's coming home with me."

And he said: "Well what's the difference in your baby being in your tummy and being in a pram in your home town?"

And I just had to shrug my shoulders. I was going by what my parents dictated. But we ... that ... you know ... but he did ask about the convent, how was it, how were you treated in it or that? And as I'm speaking to you I had to say: "Very well." Because we were. I thought we were.

IM: It's interesting that he asked isn't it?

PW: Yeah.

IM: And that he obviously cared a lot too.

PW: Yeah. Yeah. Well consultants are notoriously abrupt and have a God...

IM: Yeah.

PW: image of themselves, type thing.

IM: Yeah.

PW: But he ... he was very nice. Mr B was very nice too. And I could only say ... now in *name of hospital* when I had my baby, there was another lady there who lived not far from where I am from and her husband had passed away while she was pregnant ...

IM: Oh gosh!

PW: and the nun or the nurses would've made us tea and I, because I had no husband coming to visit or anybody.

IM: Yeah.

PW: I would've went down to her room, she was in a wee side-room, and we would've had tea there. And the nurses would've made a tray of tea [after] visiting hour was over. I still see her,

IM: I'm surprised [inaudible] ...

PW: I still see her from where I live ...

IM: Yeah.

PW: and we would still meet up and chat a bit and that.

IM: Yeah.

PW: So you know, it was they were ...

IM: Decent.

PW: Discreet.

IM: And decent.

PW: You know, yeah.

IM: And thoughtful.

PW: Yeah. And it was ... I ... we're talking about 197*. The height of the Troubles. All of that going on and turning up pregnant, at the age ... you know? Bordering between fifteen/ sixteen. Girls I went to school with would, when I come home, would've crossed the road.

IM: Because you were pregnant?

PW: Whether it was because you were an unmarried mother or whether it was because they didn't know what to say?

IM: Yeah.

PW: You know, then I felt snubbed and angry as with the age of maturity, you think did they know what to say to you?

IM: Yeah.

PW: Embarrassment, whatever.

IM: Yeah.

PW: So you know, that ... but when ... the first day I come home my mother had a beautiful brown brand-new pram, big pram. Lovely, like a silver-cross pram, now not the big tin-bodied ones that there was years ago, but this was lovely soft brown one. And it was spank brand-new.

IM: Yeah.

PW: Where she got the money from, to this day I don't know. Because we wouldn't have been a very rich family, we were working-class, and I'll never forget her saying to me ... she was taking me down to the doctor, which you had to go down through part ... the good part of the town to get to the clinic, and she had said to me: "Now, you wheel that pram and you don't get off the footpath for anybody and you don't drop your head, you keep your head up at all times." And she went with me and it was like a march, a military operation that you know, nobody was gonna stand in her way, and nobody was going to

stand in the way of her first grandchild and that. It was ... she was very good, she was ... for a woman ... she'd have been in her, in think in her forties then and she was determined nobody was going to look down on anybody belonging to her. You know ...

IM: She was remarkable.

PW: ... she could say what she wanted and thought what she wanted but nobody else was allowed to.

IM: Yep.

PW: In that type of way and whenever I found out I was pregnant and told her, it was one of the rare times I've ever seen my mother cry. So I had left the gate open at the front of the house because I thought 'oh God, get out of here if she starts ...' but no, she just ... she was draining a pot of potatoes, I can still see her, into the sink and my older brother was with me and whenever he said: "This one's pregnant" she dropped the pot into the sink and turned and said: "Is it any wonder you're putting on weight?" and went up the stairs past me crying. And I felt so, so small [PW is emotional here and her voice breaks] but the old fella had been away, he worked in *distant location* and he didn't come home ... that was a Monday or a Tuesday, he didn't come home to Thursday. And when the car pulled up at the door, Mummy was waiting and she says: "Get into the bathroom, lock yourself in the bathroom and don't come out til I tell you to. No matter what he says you stay in there." Which I did, until she spoke to him and calmed him down and whatever. But, my father was of the era where he had said, when I did eventually come out of the bathroom, it didn't matter who I ever married, or if I got married, the child would always be a bastard.

IM: That's very tough.

PW: And he never ever really let go of that. You know, it was...

IM: Wasn't your mother something though?

PW: Ahh my mother was a woman before her time.

IM: She knew exactly the way he would react ...

PW: Yeah.

IM: and how to handle him.

PW: She was a woman before her time. And she ..

IM: So no wonder you felt safer in the ... in the

PW: Yeah. She ... I ... she never said it, but I do believe she was afraid that he would give me such a hiding ...

IM: Oh yeah.

PW: again that I would lose the baby.

IM: Yeah.

PW: You know, and that ... but it was ... it was my father's expectations, not my mother's that I wouldn't marry, that I would stay at home. The child would

be reared as a wee late one, which ... was mad because everybody knew and then I would be there to look after whoever needed looking after. It was the old Irish way ...

IM: Yep.

PW: of doing it.

IM: Yep, yep.

PW: But my mother was different. And when the child was two she encouraged me to leave home. I was just eighteen. And I did. I met a fella and I ... I went out to work when the child was about six weeks old. You had to because you ... in our house you were reared to work not to live on benefits and I met this guy at the end of September. Didn't start going with him until the February of the following year and that would've been '197*. We got married in 197*; we're still married. We went on to have three more kids and he reared my child as his own. There was no difference paid in any of them [PW's voice breaks at this point]. But, I would say that I had a more positive experience in *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home* from the nuns and the environment there than I woulda done from my own father. And

IM: It's really important to tell this story.

PW: I ... I do feel ... yes it is a debt of honour to come and tell because it's not fair that ... and I'm not saying that the atrocities that has happened in some of the homes and that across Ireland both North and South didn't happen. I don't know. If there's remains of babies and that there, well that's a story that tells itself. But I didn't experience that and I don't believe any of the girls that were

in *name of mother and baby home* same time as me would've experienced that either. Excuse me.

[pause, PW was tearful]

Yes it ... it ... it was lonely, it was my first time away from home, but

IM: But you would've been lonely anywhere.

PW: Yeah. You know it was ...

IM: If you'd gone to school or you know, something like that.

PW: If I'd of been home I'd have been constantly looking over my shoulder.

IM: [speaking together] Even if you go on holidays in those days you'd get lonely.

PW: So to me, it was a safe place to be. I ... you had your dinners, your breakfast, your lunch, your dinner, your teas whatever, and in the evening time, if there was nothing on the television or that, which there wouldn't have been a whole pile in 197*, there was one particular girl there and she was learning to play the guitar and she played in the evening time. And all ... it was the first time I'd ever heard *Bobby McGee and Me*, and every time I hear that song this day I still think of that girl.

IM: It's amazing what triggers things like that isn't it?

PW: Yeah and, you know, every time I go past it even to this day I bless myself. Going past *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, because there was a chapel ... a church ... a chapel in it and we ... yes you were in a Catholic convent, you were taken up to Mass on the holy days, Sundays, confessions, all of that but you weren't made to go to confession or anything. It was there if you wanted it. But, yes, you were encouraged to go to Mass. Now there was ... I know for a fact one particular girl was from the Protestant faith and she went to Mass with us. But she was treated the same as everybody else.

IM: And why do you think she was there?

PW: She was from the Republic of Ireland.

IM: Yeah.

PW: and

IM: Was is that there was nowhere suitable for her to go? Or jus...

PW: I think it was a case of her baby was going for adoption ...

IM: Yeah.

PW: and it was, you know, as far away from the Republic of Ireland...

IM: as possible

PW: although it's all over the bloody border.

IM: Yeah.

PW: But you know, that way it was.

IM: And do you know how far South [she] was from or anything?

PW: Don't know, she had a very broad Southern accent.

IM: Yeah.

PW: Very quiet girl, kept herself to herself.

IM: Yeah.

PW: But you know, people got on together and there was two girls there, on hindsight, looking back, I think they were, nowadays would have been classed as high-ability learning disability.

IM: Yeah.

PW: You know, which must have been very hard on them and very confusing.

IM: Yeah.

PW: On ... because their babies were going for adoption. Their families were insisting. It was ... it was ... to me it was families and circumstances that dictated that these girls give their babies up.

IM: Did you ever have a discussion with your mother about whether or not ... or did she ...?

PW: Oh no it was never a ... an option.

IM: It was just assumed? Yeah.

PW: No, it was never an option.

IM: That was lovely wasn't it.

PW: The child was coming home and that was it.

IM: Yeah.

PW: And all the neighbours knew you were pregnant and that you were away from home until the child was born. Mummy never made a secret of that and diff-

IM: She was really a genius ...

PW: Yeah.

IM: wasn't she?

PW: People would have went up and down and they'd have said: "Well", using mummy's Christian name, "what about her? Any word yet?"

"No nothing yet."

IM: Yeah.

PW: Because we had no phone in the house, or anything and they had to go down to a payphone ...

IM: To phone and see?

PW: to phone at the bottom of the estate, to see.

IM: These are the things that modern generations don't know, that's what we all had to do.

PW: Yeah.

IM: And you'd have the paper number written down and a few coins to put in the ... Press Button A and Press Button B to get through, you know?

PW: Yeah. She ... no, my mother was a woman with a vision far beyond her years. She was quite an intelligent woman but didn't shine it, if you know what I mean?

IM: Yeah.

PW: She married young, had nine kids, one deceased. God knows how many miscarriages she had and ended up having to ...*details of illness*.

IM: Yeah.

PW: and that near killed her, because she was devout Catholic. But whenever my child come along, it was just another child to be reared and that was it.

IM: And had that happened already by the time your baby was born?

PW: Yeah.

IM: Yeah. What age did she live to then? Out of curiosity?

PW: She ... my mother died at age *age and cause of death* .

IM: Oh gosh!

PW: And, you know, she had a hard life but she was a good woman ...

IM: Yeah.

PW: ... and she was good to us as kids.

IM: She had amazing philosophies didn't she? She was really sensible.

PW: She ... she was ... she shot straight from the hip, in a sense.

IM: Yeah, yeah, yeah. But well thought out.

PW: Yeah. She woulda said if you know, our old fella could start a row in an empty room ...

IM: Yeah.

PW: there was no two ways about it. He's dead now too, Lord have mercy on him. But Mummy was different, Mummy woulda said ... if he said something derogatory about one of the brothers or sisters she'd have said: "Nothing to do with you, mind your own business."

IM: Yeah.

PW: They've made their bed, let them lie on it.

IM: Yeah.

PW: "Nothing to do with you, you don't know what's going to happen, you're rearing children, you don't know what ways their gonna turn out. So let it go."

IM: She should have been a role-model for mothers.

[IM and PW talking over each other]

PW: Straight to the point and no dancing about round it. You know, she didn't smoke, she didn't drink. She went to bingo.

IM: Can I ask something, that you don't have to answer? Did you have any kind of birds and bees education? Or ... lot of people didn't ...

PW: Oh no.

IM: Yeah.

PW: No. Not in the school or not at home. When I first started - when I was twelve - menstruating, and I come out of the bathroom and I said to my Mother and shouted up the stairs to my older sister to come down and she says: "Take her up, give her a Dr White [a brand of sanitary towel] and a belt and show her how to use it." That was it. It was never talked about.

IM: Yeah.

PW: You know? And then they were burnt. You had to wrap them up and keep them but when ... then they were burnt at night when everybody went to bed, or the boys weren't about.

IM: Yeah. Oh absolutely secrets.

[Talking together]

IM: It would come in in a brown paper bag, packages wrapped.

PW: Aye, what's in it now?

IM: And nobody would ever say. And I remember ... well I'll tell you after a story about that, but it ... the secrecy that ... and you know, when I see my daughters now just with boxes of Tampax around the place, it's so different.

PW: Yeah, yeah. But no that was very much, you didn't talk about things like that. There was no double entendre was used or anything like that. You know it was ...

IM: And no kind of contraceptive or education or anything like that?

PW: Ah God no, no.

IM: Yeah.

PW: No.

IM: So did you even know there was a possibility you could become pregnant then, do you think?

PW: I think I did ...

IM: Yeah.

PW: but it was an attitude of it'll not happen to me.

IM: To me, yeah. Yeah.

PW: You know? And then I was putting on weight, left right and centre and couldn't understand it. And I wasn't regular anyway, with my cycles so when it didn't come it didn't bug me really.

IM: Bother you, yeah.

PW: And then I went, I thought I had a kidney infection and I went to the doctor and she said: "Hop up on the bed." And I hopped up and she examined me and she says: "'You're approximately five months pregnant.'" And I said ...

IM: Just as well you're on the bed!

PW: Yeah. You know and I ... God, and she ... I had to go home and tell this. But it was ... oh. I come out of it and to this day I still don't know how I got home. Do you know the thinking of it and what ... when you know ... and this weight I had on. And yes it was logical because it was on my tummy, you know? I couldn't get in my school uniform and couldn't button the skirt at the back. You know that.

IM: Yeah, yeah. Yeah.

PW: But I just ... I was greenhorn. Didn't know.

IM: Sure we all were.

PW: Even ... even after the child was born I was a greenhorn because they had said use Epsom Salts but I didn't know that you actually mixed them up and drank them, for your ... to drain the milk from your breasts. So I put them in the bath and lay on my tummy in the bath, you know?

IM: Yeah, yeah.

PW: That's how much education ...

IM: Yeah, I know.

PW: ... you got, or whatever. Although the health visitor, she's deceased now too, she was lovely. And the ... the dole wanted you to go down to be interviewed and she said: "No, this girl's not fit to go down, you'll have to come out to her and interview her, with her parents there." I was also

interviewed by the police because in Northern Ireland ... I don't know what the age is now, but in 197* the legal age for sexual intercourse was

IM: Sixt-

PW: Seventeen.

IM: Seventeen.

PW: And I was sixteen. And the police come to *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home* ... policewoman - which nearly put our old fella [PW's father] cuckoo - and interviewed me.² [the father was also a teenage boy and, ultimately, there was no action taken]

... But it ... I ... I couldn't say I had a negative experience with the nuns in *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. I have a lot to be thankful for to the nuns [there]. And a lot of women, I feel, have that. And, you know, people should be speaking up and saying what their times were like and that. The sixties, it was bad all round. You know, you had girls in England were sent home to Ireland to have babies, you had girls in Ireland sent to England. You know it's ... it was the times.

IM: So you think maybe that things had moved on by the seventies? When you got to that stage? That society was a little bit more accepting?

PW: No, it wasn't.

² The baby's father was PW's teenage boyfriend.

IM: Yeah.

PW: It was very much ... you know, I'm talking about days when you ... when you had your child in the pram and you were out ... you could park it outside a shop and go in and do your shopping, come back out and the pram would still have been there.

IM: Yeah.

PW: You wouldn't do that now, you wouldn't contemplate doing it now.

IM: No.

PW: You know? There was very few shops big enough for you to take prams in round, because they were big prams then. They weren't these small skinny things they have now. And your baby was strapped in it and there was like a harness, was hooked onto the side, each thing. You know, that it ... to me they were innocent times. You know, because you ... you walked your baby during the day. You had it out in the pram and you walked the roads. You know, that way. It ... it wasn't the way it is now.

IM: Yeah.

PW: You know, even my other kids, they'd have been popped in the pram outside, in the good weather. Mummy got a wee gate made, it was ... it was a door, off a cupboard for the front door, that the child could walk up and down, to the front door and look out. Once he started on his foot. So you know, I stayed at home until he was two and half, and then I got married and moved out. And my father just didn't want to know.

IM: And that's been hard, hasn't it?

PW: Yeah. Yeah. But my mother ... I have a lot to be thankful for because she was ... she was just brilliant.

IM: It's just coming up to 12 o'clock and I'm aware you have a ticket on the [parking] meter, is that nearly out?

PW: No, it'll be ... it's ...

talking together

PW: It's alright. Is there anything else that ...

IM: You mentioned something there about ... was it dole or something? Was that ...

PW: Yeah. The bru³ we called it then.

IM: Yeah.

PW: You were entitled to £12.45 a week.

IM: So you signed on in the convent was it ...?

PW: The nuns arranged that. They arranged that.

³ A term for benefits deriving from when unemployment offices were called bureau (hence bru).

IM: And did you get the money or did they get the money?

PW: They got most of it, but you got some of it ...

IM: Ok.

PW: ... for toiletries and things like that, but it was your upkeep ...

IM: Yeah.

PW: ... and the convent as well had to be paid for.

IM: That twelve ... I'm trying to think at that stage ... I would've begun working a little bit after that and would have been getting ... maybe four years after that and got £40 gross a week. So, that would just something ... so it'd be about half what you might get in a job I suppose, a fairly ordinary job. I was in a clerical job, so you know, it'd be ...

PW: Well that, yeah, that's what you got and then the ... the bru, there was some ... there was a woman come out then and she didn't want my mother in the room being interviewed. She was quite nasty.

IM: Yeah. Was this at home or in the convent?

PW: Yeah, no at home.

IM: Yeah.

PW: And Mummy put her in her place. Mummy just says: “No, this is my house.” She says: “You’ll not dictate what happens here, I’m mistress here.”

IM: Yeah.

PW: And she says: “You’ll not intimidate her either.” So ... that was granted; it was £12.45 a week.

IM: And that’s what you had and so you had that when you came home as well? So you had both in the ... in ... in ... in the ... home and in [family] home ...

PW: Yeah, yeah. Well then at home you ... at that stage, you had to give into the house ... towards the keep of the house and that.

IM: Yes, yeah.

PW: But then, I had very little to buy because Mummy made sure that the child was looked after, do you know what I mean?

IM: Yeah.

PW: She would’ve went down and she done all the charity shops and that she’d have got wee bits and pieces.

IM: She was a good manager.

PW: Yes.

IM: Yes, yeah.

PW: She's had to be, over the years because we were a big family and you know, we had aunts ...

IM: [Talking at the same time as PW] And regardless of how much money you have ...

PW: Yeah. We had aunts what had sent the clothes their kids grew out of, over to us and we'd nearly rake one another to get into them.

IM: Yeah.

PW: You know? So, getting clothes out of a second-hand shop, I still do it. To this day, you know. It doesn't cost me a thought to go into a charity shop and poke around it. I ... and when I left the convent and come home, there was no recriminations from the nuns or that. There was ... there was like that. You know, it was: "You've had your baby now and best of luck", type thing. I just ...

IM: It's such a ... such a different attitude to what we hear ... why do you think that is?

PW: I've thought about this and thought about it and

IM: Yeah.

PW: part of me says yes, some people would've had negative experiences. And other people may not have. But maybe mothers whose children have tracked them down, as adults, and ... it is a fraction of them now, a fraction of them

saying: “Well I had to do this, this is what I had to do and I was made to do it and ...”. You know, a part of me thinks that.

IM: And the support of the family obviously made a big difference.

PW: Yes. Oh God yeah.

IM: Yeah.

PW: Yeah. There was no two ways about that. You know, health visitors would come to the house, they were all dead on and they’d say to you, you know: “Listen to your mother because you’ll not go wrong.” She had the experience of her family behind her.

IM: So do you think that might be another thing, that the fact that they knew you’d a strong and stable family and a very sensible mother maybe changed their attitude to you as well?

PW: Probably, but my mother would’ve been very much straight out and I’m kinda like her in that way myself. You know? If something’s to be said, say it, move on, forget it then.

IM: Get over it.

PW: Get over it, build a bridge, that’s it. It’s done and dusted. You move on with your life. You know that way. She adored my husband, thought there was nobody like him; My father hated him with a passion. And he [PW’s husband] ... he just loved ... he just loved the child from day one. From when he met him. And we’ll be forty years married next year, God spares us. And it’s ... I’m

down here today with his full support, because he knows there has to be a balance in a ... in pieces of research, having done research myself in different pieces of things. And you know, you have to tell the truth in these things because it's no good unless you do.

IM: Thank you so much for coming forward to tell this story, is there anything else you'd like to add to it or will we ...

PW: I don't think so, I ... you know it's ...

IM: Let's leave it there then and thank you very much for coming in to do this.

PW: Thank you for asking me.

[End of recording]